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After a Dangerous Stalemate a Window of Hope

The MoU between the US and Iran marks a return to diplomacy. The really thorny issues will have to be resolved in a final agreement



WHITE HOUSE/DANIEL TOROK

The preliminary Memorandum of Understanding (MoU) between the United States and Iran has cooled the crisis without ending it. It is being described in some quarters as a breakthrough. It is certainly better than the alternative: a prolonged conflict, a blocked Strait of Hormuz, spiralling oil prices and a widening regional war. The MoU matters for India not because it was at the negotiating table, but because Indians were among those paying the bill.

It would be a mistake, however, to confuse this MoU with a comprehensive settlement. At best, it has pushed the crisis back into the diplomatic framework. At worst, it may have simply postponed the harder questions for another 60 days.

The distinction matters. The new understanding does not resolve nuclear issues presented as central to the war. It deals mainly with problems created by the recent confrontation: the disruption of shipping through Hormuz, the threat to oil flows, and the risk of wider military escalation. The older questions remain. What happens to Iran's enriched uranium stockpiles? What level of uranium enrichment will be permitted? Where will nuclear material be moved? What is the sequencing between Iran's nuclear steps and the lifting of American sanctions? These are the central issues. And they have merely been placed back on the negotiating table.

That is why this agreement should not be compared with the 2015 Joint Comprehensive Plan of Action, or JCPOA, the nuclear agreement negotiated by the Obama administration between Iran and the P5+1 powers. The JCPOA was a nuclear deal. It placed verifiable limits on Iran's nuclear programme, including enrichment levels and stockpiles, in return for sanctions relief. This MoU is not yet that. It is a ceasefire-plus diplomatic framework. It says Iran will not pursue a nuclear weapon, but that has been Iran's stated position for years. The real test is not the declaration; it is the mechanism.

President Donald Trump had originally wanted something more ambitious than the Obama deal: a "JCPOA-plus" arrangement that would address not only Iran's nuclear programme but also its ballistic missiles and regional proxies. On those two additional fronts, the MoU is strikingly thin. Ballistic missiles are not meaningfully dealt with. Iran's regional networks are not rolled back. By including language on Lebanon and ceasefires on multiple fronts, the agreement may have indirectly given Iran and its allies some breathing space. Regime change, too, has disappeared from the practical agenda. If those were the original war aims, the MoU marks a significant narrowing of American objectives.

Why, then, did Washington agree? Because the US discovered that escalation was easier to begin than to control.

THE US UNDERESTIMATED IRAN AND OVERESTIMATED THE GAINS FROM MILITARY PRESSURE. THE MOU NOW GIVES TEHRAN TIME, SOME ECONOMIC RELIEF AND A CHANCE TO EXTRACT FURTHER CONCESSIONS

Washington appears to have underestimated Iran's resilience and overestimated the prospects of military pressure producing a political collapse. The global economic cost also became too high. Energy is not a sectoral issue; it is the underpinning of the modern economy. Once oil prices and shipping risks rise, inflationary pressure spreads across transport, manufacturing, food and household budgets. For Trump, acutely sensitive to pump prices and recession risks, a continued confrontation carried domestic political dangers as well.

Iran also had reasons to step back. Its leaders have often shown tactical pragmatism when the cost of confrontation rises beyond a point. Iran had